



CASE STUDY

Vancouver Community College Applies Market Research to Launch Cybersecurity Program

Hanover Research provides academic program assessment expertise to help VCC create innovative, hands-on training, including a cybersecurity diploma.



THE INSTITUTION

Vancouver Community College

INSTITUTION TYPE

Public community college

LOCATION

Vancouver, British Columbia, Canada

THE CHALLENGE

Understand labour market trends and assess the viability of new academic programs

HANOVER SOLUTION

Academic Program Assessment,
Benchmarking and Best Practices

In the heart of Vancouver, British Columbia, Vancouver Community College (VCC) provides real-world training that connects students with accessible support and workforce success. For more than five years, VCC has entrusted Hanover Research as a strategic thought partner in its academic program assessment decisions.

Hanover's data and recommendations have helped VCC assess student and labour market demand for multiple programs, including its apprenticeship training, microcredentials, Fashion Design and Production diploma, Baking and Culinary Arts programs, and others.



140+

The number of degrees and certificates offered at VCC



12

The number of apprenticeship programs offered

THE CHALLENGE: DETERMINE ACADEMIC PROGRAM VIABILITY TO MEET LABOUR MARKET DEMAND

To continue growing programs aligned with emerging labour market needs across BC and Canada, David Wells, Vice President for Academic and Applied Research, wanted to expand the college's capacity to conduct effective market research, while freeing up faculty and staff time to pursue other endeavors.

Collaborating with Hanover allowed Wells to explore program development best practices, monitor trends, and test out proposal ideas. In particular, Wells needed to assess a queue of potential and existing academic programs, while also carefully treading around certain labour union restrictions at VCC.

In 2022, the college was specifically interested in figuring out if adding a cybersecurity program would be a positive opportunity for students and the institution, but they needed more data.

Make sure your academic programs connect to careers with tips from our webinar, **Thinking Strategically About Workforce Alignment in Higher Education.**

Download the recording.



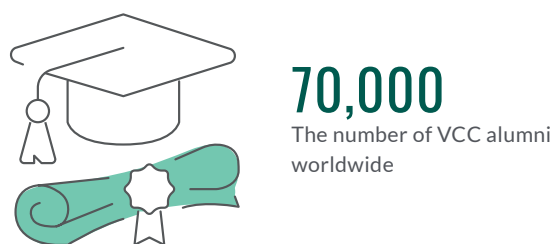
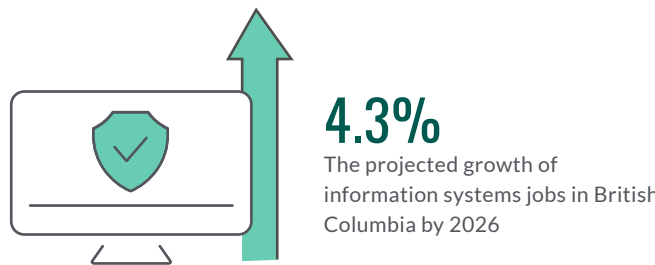
THE SOLUTION: CONDUCT MARKET RESEARCH AND ASSESS INDUSTRY WORKFORCE ALIGNMENT

To determine the viability of a potential cybersecurity program, Hanover applied its academic program assessment framework to analyze recent degree completion data, labour market demand, and competitor programs.

This comprehensive analysis revealed actionable insights, including:

- Cybersecurity-related academic programs are growing in student headcount in British Columbia
- Both the British Columbia and Canadian governments stress a cyber skills gap in the province and country
- Benchmarked cybersecurity programs focused on preparing entry-level cybersecurity professionals, with only one offering an industry certification option
- Program specializations focused on either general cybersecurity or a sub-specialty of cybersecurity

Hanover’s team also provided a structure for sharing preliminary market insights with VCC early in a new program’s development phase, which helped Wells and others understand the overall landscape and trends before investing additional resources to solicit more detailed data. This two-step approach allows college leaders to more efficiently determine which program ideas are viable and which ones may need modifications to move forward.

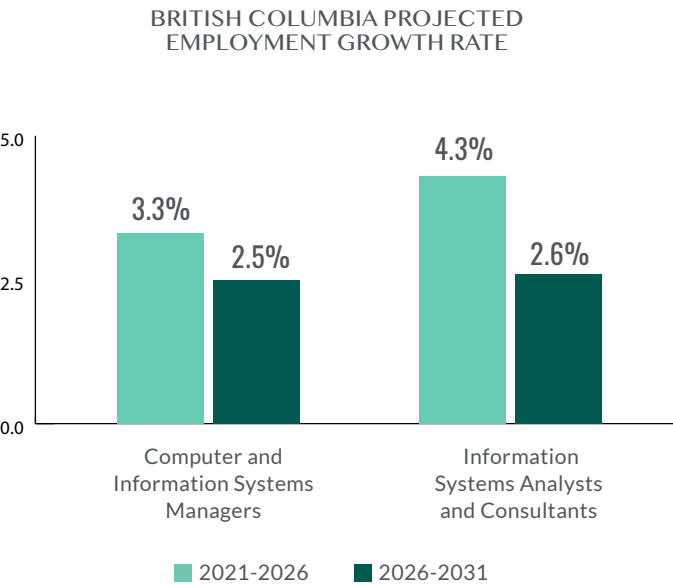


THE OUTCOME: ACADEMIC PROGRAM DECISIONS BASED ON DATA AND RESEARCH

In July 2022, Hanover recommended that VCC develop a cybersecurity credential and include an industry certification option, not only to differentiate the program, but also to ensure graduates’ job-readiness.

With this data, VCC moved forward and approved a new two-year, post-degree diploma in Cybersecurity Governance, Risk, and Compliance. Launched in fall 2024, the program is designed to help fill BC’s and Canada’s skill gap in the cybersecurity field.

To retain its position as an educational leader, VCC continues to partner with Hanover to develop forward-looking academic programs that meet BC’s student and workforce needs. Wells and the Hanover team are currently investigating clean energy programs and other credentials.



Get the latest data on rising occupations with our infographic, **Top Career Skills for New Grads in 2024**.

[Get the infographic.](#)

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